sixty-one persons: forty-three crew members and eighteen extras—passengers, trainees, and harbor pilots. Now it had to accommodate 250 extras—officers and enlisted men. Since they had to be concealed, for most of the long trip they would be confined to bunks between decks, suffering from immobility and extremely high temperatures beneath decks heated by the sun. Sidorov recalled that when a Turkish harbor pilot came aboard to guide the ship through the Bosporus, the soldiers were ordered to stay between decks, repeatedly watching the 1958 three-part Soviet film epic *And Quiet Flows the Don*. What was also flowing was their sweat. When Sidorov and others who stayed on deck opened the hatches between decks, they saw steam rising. Only when the lights of Istanbul were behind them did they let the soldiers out to breathe some fresh air.[9]

The living or, rather, breathing conditions on the *Omsk* were more the rule than the exception when compared to other ships taking missiles, equipment, and military personnel to Cuba. "The portholes between decks were covered with canvas blinds, and because of poor ventilation the temperature there sometimes reached 50°C and more," wrote Viktor Yesin, deputy chief engineer of one of the missile regiments. A major challenge was to keep the temperature of the hydrogen peroxide below 35 degrees Celsius. Sidorov and his people managed to keep the temperature around 28 degrees—quite an achievement in conditions when the temperature in the tween decks in cargo holds was almost twice as high. There was another problem when they left the Mediterranean and began their journey across the Atlantic, as Lieutenant Valentin Polkovnikov, a financial officer of a missile regiment, recalled: "The rocking motion increased, but people bore it as best they could." According to Yesin, "A great many servicemen (almost 75 percent) were seasick."[10]

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THE THIRTY-SEVEN-YEAR-OLD COLONEL DMITRII YAZOV, WHO would become the last Soviet minister of defense under Mikhail Gorbachev, left the Soviet Union for Cuba on board the German-built ocean liner *Victory*—a subtle reminder that the ship, built in 1928, had been taken from Germany by the